

- 1) Work creates income.
- 2) Income creates lifestyle/debt (cars, boats, designer clothes).
- 3) Lifestyle/debt forces work.
- 4) Repeat . . .

I learned about Lifestyle Servitude in my early 20s. After college graduation, I took a hellacious job as a construction laborer in Chicago and fought city traffic daily. The pay was more than I had ever earned at my young age, and with my increase in income, I felt wealthy. So what did I do? I elevated my lifestyle and financed the illusion of wealth. I bought my first sports car, a Mitsubishi 3000GT.

It didn't take long for me to realize that my dream car wasn't an icon of wealth, but a parasite that fed on my freedom. I hated my job, it was stressful, and it drained my energy, leaving my entrepreneurial dreams tethered. I couldn't quit. I had responsibilities: car payments, gas, and insurance. Because of my obligations to "stuff," I had sentenced myself to imprisonment in a job I loathed.

Yet, this type of servitude is normal. We're taught to strive for the latest and greatest regardless of consequence. It leaves us indentured for years, condemning us to lifestyle imprisonment... and the more stuff you buy that you can't afford, the longer your jail sentence becomes.

IF YOU THINK YOU CAN AFFORD IT—YOU CAN'T

Think about the last time you bought a pack of gum. Did you fret over the price? Did you ask, "Hmmm, can I afford this?" Probably not. You bought the gum and it's done. The purchase had no impact on your lifestyle or your future choices. To a rich man who walks into a dealership and buys a six-figure Bentley without thought, the acts are the same.

Affordability is when you don't have to think about it. If you have to think about "affordability," you can't afford it because affordability carries conditions and consequences. If you buy a boat and resort to mental gymnastics over affordability, **YOU CAN'T AFFORD IT.** Sure you can assuage affordability and make outlandish arguments, often starting with "I can afford this as long as . . .

- . . . I get that promotion."
- . . . my mortgage doesn't adjust."
- . . . my stock portfolio makes another 10% this month!"
- . . . my sales forecasts are double."
- . . . my wife finds a job."
- . . . I cancel my health insurance."

This self-talk is a warning that you can't afford it. Affordability doesn't come with strings attached. You can bluff yourself but you can't bluff the consequences.